

Some experts believe that leg cramps may be caused by a lack of calcium or salt or an excess of phosphorus, but these theories are as yet unproven.

When you get a spasm, relieve it by flexing your foot or leg (see far right), and gently massaging the affected area. The cramp should resolve itself once you are out of bed and using the muscle. However, if the pain doesn't recede and there is any reddening or swelling in the leg, you should seek medical advice immediately to eliminate the possibility of a clot (see [Ask a doctor](#)), since this can be dangerous.

To reduce the incidence or severity of cramping, drink a lot of water to prevent dehydration. Also do leg stretches and ankle exercises regularly, especially before bedtime, circling your heel and wiggling your toes.

Gentle exercise, such as walking or swimming, can also help, as can regularly massaging the calf muscle to improve circulation.